

The National Residue Survey (NRS) contracts the services of Australian and New Zealand laboratories to perform residue testing. The laboratories must have demonstrated capabilities in the specific chemical residue analyses that are required by export and domestic markets.

Laboratory performance evaluation (LPE)

NRS laboratory performance evaluation activities, generally based on proficiency testing (PT), seek to make regular and objective evaluations of contract laboratory competency. They are designed to maintain an up-to-date and continuing assessment of the proficiency of laboratories that are analysing samples for NRS or seeking to offer such services in the future.

We recognise the suitability of laboratories for export testing of produce based on such demonstrated competency. Laboratory performance evaluation also helps to ensure the quality of the analytical testing service delivered to participating industries.

Participating in proficiency testing

NRS contract laboratories are required to participate in all relevant, scheduled PT conducted by the NRS for the entire contract term. In addition, NRS PT is open to any other Australian laboratory currently testing chemical–commodity combinations included in the NRS suite of programs for which an NRS PT program is offered. Overseas laboratories may also participate where circumstances permit (e.g. stability of chemicals, import conditions, courier requirements).

Participation in NRS PT is free of charge, however in the case of overseas laboratories, additional charges may apply to cover courier costs and phytosanitary certificates.

Role of the Laboratory Performance Evaluation Committee

The primary role of the LPE Committee is to advise on the PT schemes run by the NRS. The LPE Committee examines analytical PT results and their statistical interpretation, where relevant, to rank laboratory performance.

Members of the LPE Committee may also provide feedback on the planning and implementation of proficiency tests, and perform random audits of individual participant results.

National Association of Testing Authorities (NATA) accreditation

The NRS is accredited by the [NATA](#) as a Proficiency Scheme Testing Provider as assessed against ISO/IEC 17043, but is not itself a laboratory accreditation body. The NRS recognises and supports the role of NATA as the principal agent of laboratory accreditation, and the relevant nationally and internationally defined standards.

NATA accreditation (or international equivalent) is generally required by any laboratory providing chemical analytical services to the NRS. However, the NRS does not require a laboratory to hold (or be seeking) NATA accreditation, either in a particular test or in chemical residue analysis, as a precondition of participation in NRS PT. Where appropriate, participation in the NRS PT may assist in gaining or maintaining of its accreditation.

In the case of overseas laboratories, the NRS recognises accreditation by bodies that are signatories to the [International Laboratory Accreditation Cooperation \(ILAC\)](#) Mutual Recognition Arrangement (often referred to as the ILAC Arrangement).

Laboratory procurement process

All information relating to provision of chemical analytical testing for the NRS can be accessed through [AusTender](#). The 13th term contracts run from 1 July 2024 to 30 June 2027, with the possibility of extension to 30 June 2029.

The 13th term contracted laboratories and their respective testing programs are listed below:

Meat, Seafood and Eggs

Testing programs

Program number	Program name	Contract laboratory
Program 1	Antimicrobials in kidney, poultry liver, eggs and seafood	QDAF CRL
Program 3	Phenicol in muscle and seafood	AsureQuality
Program 3E	Phenicol in eggs	AsureQuality
Program 4	Nitrofurantoin metabolites in muscle, eggs and seafood	AsureQuality
Program 4I	Nitrofurantoin metabolites in retina	AsureQuality
Program 5A	Nitroimidazoles in muscle, eggs and seafood	AsureQuality
Program 5B	Olaquinox and carbadox in liver	AsureQuality
Program 6A	Stilbenes, zearanol and trenbolone in liver	AsureQuality
Program 6C	Stilbenes, zearanol and trenbolone in faeces	Symbio Laboratories
Program 7	Beta-agonists in liver	AsureQuality
Program 8	Pesticides in fat and eggs	Symbio Laboratories
Program 10	Cyromazine, melamine and dicyclanil in kidney	QDAF CRL
Program 11	Anthelmintics in liver	AsureQuality
Program 12	Macrocyclic lactones, spinosyns and other anthelmintics in fat and seafood	Symbio Laboratories
Program 15	Triclabendazole in liver	Symbio Laboratories
Program 16	Metals in liver and eggs	Symbio Laboratories

Program 18	Dioxins in fat	AsureQuality
Program 20	Androgenic substances in urine	AsureQuality
Program 23	Nonsteroidal anti-inflammatory drugs in kidney	QDAF CRL
Program 27	Anticoccidials in liver and eggs	Symbio Laboratories
Program 28	Benzoyl ureas in fat	Symbio Laboratories
Program 31	Acrylonitrile and vinyl chloride in eggs	AsureQuality
Program 32	Indicator PCBs in eggs	AsureQuality
Program 33	Quinolones and fluoroquinolones in kidney	QDAF CRL
Program 35	Corticosteroids in liver	AsureQuality
Program 37	Herbicides in kidney	Symbio Laboratories
Program 38	Anaesthetics in fat	AsureQuality
Program 39	Imidocarb in kidney	Symbio Laboratories
NARM Screening	Urine screening	Southern Scientific Services
NARM/TART Confirmatory	Kidney confirmatory testing	QDAF CRL

Seafood Testing Programs

Program number	Program name	Contract laboratory
Program 306	Steroids in seafood	AsureQuality
Program 308	Pesticides in seafood	AsureQuality
Program 316	Metals in seafood	Symbio Laboratories
Program 317	Dyes in seafood	AsureQuality
Program 333	Quinolones and fluoroquinolones in seafood	QDAF CRL

Honey Testing Programs

Program number	Program name	Contract laboratory
Program 201	Antimicrobials in honey	QDAF CRL
Program 203	Phenolics in honey	AsureQuality
Program 204	Nitrofurantoin metabolites in honey	AsureQuality
Program 206	Metals in honey	Symbio Laboratories
Program 208	Pesticides in honey	AsureQuality
Program 209	Paradichlorobenzene in honey	QDAF CRL

Grains Testing Programs

Program number	Program name	Contract laboratory
Program 42	Phosphine in cereal grains, flour, bran, pulses, and oilseeds	Agrifood Technology

Program 46	Metals in cereal grains, flour, bran, pulses, and oilseeds	Symbio Laboratories
Program 49	Multi-residue pesticide screen in cereal grains, flour, bran, pulses and oilseeds	Symbio Laboratories
Program 49H	Herbicides in cereal grains, flour, bran, pulses and oilseeds, macadamia nuts and almonds	Symbio Laboratories
Program 49I	Imidazolinone herbicides in cereal grains, pulses and oilseeds	Symbio Laboratories

Horticulture Testing Programs

Program number	Program name	Contract laboratory
Program 142	Phosphine in almonds	AgriFood Technology
Program 156	Metals in macadamia nuts, almonds, apples and pears	Symbio Laboratories
Program 157	Microbiology in apples and pears	AgriFood Technology
Program 169	Multi-residue pesticide screen including dithiocarbamates in macadamia nuts, almonds, apples and pears	Symbio Laboratories
Program 179	Patulin in apple and pear juice	AsureQuality

Testing and reporting of results

For the information of laboratories wishing to undertake contract work, the NRS specifies and publishes LOR (Limit of Reporting) values for each chemical–commodity combination required for NRS tests. These values are published in the 'National Residue Survey Proficiency Tests Handbook'. To request a copy [Contact us - National Residue Survey](#).

Laboratory method LORs would generally be expected to be less than or equal to the NRS specified values. A contract laboratory must report quantitative results for analytes detected above the laboratory's method LOR, irrespective of the level at which the NRS LOR has been set. Detections of an analyte above the laboratory's method LOD (Limit of Detection), but less than the laboratory's method LOR, must also be reported.

All analytes reported at or above the laboratory's method LOD must have been identified in a manner consistent with the criteria outlined in the European Commission Decision 2002/657/EC. To see a copy [Contact us - National Residue Survey](#).